REBUILDING THE TRUST

THE WEEKLONG 'BACK TO VILLAGE' PROGRAMME—NOW IN ITS FOURTH YEAR—HAS SEEN HUGE PARTICIPATION IN RURAL J&K. THIS MAJOR OUTREACH THAT AIMS TO USHER IN EQUITABLE DEVELOPMENT IS HELPING TO RESTORE FAITH IN THE ADMINISTRATION

By Moazum Mohammad in Srinagar

Under the early winter sky, there is an unusual festive rush in rural Kashmir. Roads have been tidied up with edges marked with white gypsum, and signboards announce the return of the 'Back to Village' (B2V) programme, a platform connecting the masses with the government across villages in Jammu and Kashmir. In Ganderbal's Wanihama village, a 30-minute drive from Srinagar, locals arrive at the government school to register their grievances with designated officers drawn from 35 departments. Over the next few hours, the villagers put forward their demands, ranging from development of parks and repair of roads to laying of new power cables. As the officials break for lunch, an old woman urges them to visit her neighbourhood. They oblige and follow her to find that the lane leading to her house is still partially done up with paving stones. "I don't know why the remaining portion was left out. *Magar be chas amich umeed heth, tuh karav moun maslee theek yatee* (I came with the hope that my grievance will be redressed)," she says in Kashmiri. The officials promise her it will be done, listing it as a 'priority'.

This is the fourth edition of the Back to Village (B2V4) programme since its launch in June 2019, two months before the Union government revoked Jammu and Kashmir's special constitutional status (Article 370) and bifurcated the state into the Union territories (UTs) of J&K and Ladakh on August 5. For years, due to militancy, red tape and vested interests, governance took a backseat in rural J&K, leaving scores of villages deprived of even basic amenities such as roads, water supply and electricity. "No one would listen to us. We had to travel to Srinagar or Jammu to just meet our representatives. But our grievances were never resolved," says Ahmadullah Khan, 55, sarpanch of Tulail's Barnoi village in north Kashmir's Gurez. Khan cites the example of Shikari village, 160 km from Srinagar, where snowslides frequently damaged houses. The plea for a protection wall remained unfulfilled till it was listed at a B2V camp.

The picturesque Gurez valley falls along the Line of Control in north Kashmir—known for bloody clashes between Indian and Pakistani armies—and lags far behind on development parameters, with hundreds of residents cut off from the rest of the country due to heavy snow between November and April. The past three years, though, have seen a perceptible change on the ground. Besides new roads and other infrastructural development, a chopper service connects the region to Srinagar in winters. Murtaza Lone, 27, a local student currently pursuing a masters in public administration, lists a number of reasons why the region's rural economy has blossomed. In 2021, mobile connectivity was re-



ABID BHAT

GRASSROOTS DEMOCRACY
People meet government officials at a 'Back to Village' camp in Budgam, Nov. 3

277
Cooperative societies registered